Rugged Individualism

Herbert Hoover · campaign speech · New York City · October 22, 1928 · excerpts

Source: Herbert Hoover, campaign address, New York City (Oct. 22, 1928), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Two weeks before he won the presidency, Hoover gave his major economic-philosophy speech at Madison Square Garden. He contrasted American 'rugged individualism' with what he saw as the European tradition of state paternalism. The speech aged badly: less than a year later the Great Depression began, and Hoover's reluctance to use federal power to address it became the central liability of his presidency.

Connect: Hoover's laissez-faire approach in 1929-33 was consistent with Republican philosophy since McKinley. What broke this consensus by 1932?

Key Passages

On American distinctiveness

When the war closed, the most vital of all issues both in our own country and throughout the world was whether governments should continue their wartime ownership and operation of many instrumentalities of production and distribution. We were challenged with a peacetime choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines—doctrines of paternalism and state socialism. The acceptance of these ideas would have meant the destruction of self-government through centralization of government.

On equality of opportunity

The very essence of equality of opportunity and of American individualism is that there shall be no domination by any group or combination in this Republic, whether it be business or political. On the contrary, it demands economic justice as well as political and social justice. It is no system of laissez faire.

On government and business

We are nearer today to the ideal of the abolition of poverty and fear from the lives of men and women than ever before in any land. And I again repeat that the departure from our American system by injecting principles destructive to it which our opponents propose will jeopardize the very liberty and freedom of our people, will destroy equality of opportunity not alone to ourselves but to our children.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Prosperity of the 1920s under Republican presidents and laissez-faire policy; Hoover was running for president in 1928 against Democrat Al Smith.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Voters in the 1928 election; Republicans at Madison Square Garden and a national radio audience.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Herbert Hoover, a successful engineer, businessman, and commerce secretary who believed in voluntary cooperation and limited government.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HIPP for 3 docs (1 pt): Practice writing one sentence each of Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for Hoover's speech.
2. Identify ONE specific 1930s policy Hoover would have called 'state paternalism.'
3. How does this speech's framing of poverty differ from FDR's First Inaugural five years later?

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> In the closing days of the 1928 campaign, Hoover defended "the American system of rugged individualism" against what he called European "paternalism and state socialism" — a philosophy soon tested by the Great Depression.

The American system

After the war, when the Republican Party assumed administration of the country, we were faced with the problem of determination of the very nature of our national life. During 150 years we have builded up a form of self-government and a social system which is peculiarly our own. It differs essentially from all others in the world. It is the American system. It is just as definite and positive a political and social system as has ever been developed on earth. It is founded upon a particular conception of self-government in which decentralized local responsibility is the very base. Further than this, it is founded upon the conception that only through ordered liberty, freedom, and equal opportunity to the individual will his initiative and enterprise spur on the march of progress. And in our insistence upon equality of opportunity has our system advanced beyond all the world.

[. . .]

Rugged individualism

When the war closed, the most vital of all issues both in our own country and throughout the world was whether governments should continue their wartime ownership and operation of many instrumentalities of production and distribution. We were challenged with a peacetime choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines—doctrines of paternalism and state socialism. The acceptance of these ideas would have meant the destruction of self-government through centralization of government. It would have meant the undermining of the individual initiative and enterprise through which our people have grown to unparalleled greatness. . . . When the Republican Party came into full power it went at once resolutely back to our fundamental conception of the state and the rights and responsibilities of the individual. Thereby, it restored confidence and hope in the American people, it freed and stimulated enterprise, it restored the Government to its position as an umpire instead of a player in the economic game.

[. . .]

Government in business

There is, therefore, submitted to the American people a question of fundamental principle. That is: Shall we depart from the principles of our American political and economic system, upon which we have advanced beyond all the rest of the world, in order to adopt methods based on principles destructive of its very foundations? . . . Bureaucracy is ever desirous of spreading its influence and its power. You cannot extend the mastery of the Government over the daily working life of a people without at the same time making it the master of the people's souls and thoughts.

[. . .]

Equality of opportunity

Nor do I wish to be misinterpreted as believing that the United States is free-for-all and devil-take-the-hind-most. The very essence of equality of opportunity and of American individualism is that there shall be no domination by any group or combination in this Republic, whether it be business or political. On the contrary, it demands economic justice as well as

political and social justice. It is no system of laissez faire. . . . It is just as important that business keep out of government as that government keep out of business.

[. . .]

Results of the American system

By adherence to the principles of decentralized self-government, ordered liberty, equal opportunity, and freedom to the individual, our American experiment in human welfare has yielded a degree of well being unparalleled in all the world. It has come nearer to the abolition of poverty, to the abolition of fear of want, than humanity has ever reached before. . . . We have in this short period decreased the fear of poverty, the fear of unemployment, the fear of old age; and these are fears that are the greatest calamities of humankind.

[. . .]

Conclusion

We are nearer today to the ideal of the abolition of poverty and fear from the lives of men and women than ever before in any land. And I again repeat that the departure from our American system by injecting principles destructive to it which our opponents propose will jeopardize the very liberty and freedom of our people, will destroy equality of opportunity not alone to ourselves but to our children. . . . My conception of America is a land where men and women may walk in ordered freedom in the independent conduct of their occupations; where they may enjoy the advantages of wealth, not concentrated in the hands of the few but spread through the lives of all; where they build and safeguard their homes, and give to their children the fullest advantages and opportunities of American life; where every man shall be respected in the faith that his conscience and his heart direct him to follow; where a contented and happy people, secure in their liberties, free from poverty and fear, shall have the leisure and impulse to seek a fuller life.

Words to know

instrumentalities — the tools and systems of the economy, such as railroads and factories

rugged individualism — Hoover's phrase for self-reliance with minimal government help

paternalism — government caring for citizens like a parent, limiting their independence

state socialism — government ownership and control of industry

Bureaucracy — government agencies and officials, pictured as always seeking more power

laissez faire — hands-off policy in which government does not regulate business